since 2021. Though the situation in the Valley is under control, some 35-40 foreign terrorists are said to be operating in Jammu's border districts. Just the second week of June saw terrorists strike at four places in Reasi, Kathua and Doda districts. The attack in Reasi on a bus carrying pilgrims from the Shiv Khori temple on June 9, in which nine were killed, was the most dastardly. Many interpreted it as a message of malintent from Pakistan's army, coming as it did on the day the new NDA regime formally took over.

"Terrorists are desperate to undermine the peace process. Conducting peaceful polls will be a challenge. Still, we all are geared up," says a key defence official. The army's Nagrota-based 16 Corps, which guards the Line of Control from Akhnoor to Poonch south of the Pir Panjal, has had little success since November-December 2023, when several terrorists were killed in encounters in Bajimaal (Rajouri) and Dehra ki Gali (Poonch), though at the cost of losing nine security personnel. Presently, patrolling and drone and satellite surveillance have been intensified. It's a time of difficult optimism as all the strands in the former/future state's story converge yet again. "The recent voter turnout reflects a growing faith in the democratic process," says an army officer. A repeat show would be the ideal way forward in Kashmir. ■

an outlier is the fact that other states have procured at either the same levels as last year or even more.

This is especially striking because Madhya Pradesh offers a higher procurement price for wheat than all other states—Rs 2,400 per quintal compared to Rs 2,275, since it pays Rs 125 as bonus per quintal. You would imagine that was sufficient to get its wheat-growers to make a beeline for the procurement centres. But the unexplained lethargy is of such an order that many are wondering if it will end

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